

The Buccaneer of the Turtle

By Mélissa

For my pirate friends in Second Life

First English version, poorly translated from original French text, translation done entirely by chat-gpt



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Part 1

Chapter 1 : The Hideout of the Brethren of the Coast

A fine tropical rain falls on Tortuga, Turtle Island, on this late afternoon of the year 1667. The port seethes with activity despite the drizzle: curses mix with the laughter of drunken pirates, the creaking of hulls tossed by the swell, and the snapping of flags whipped by the salty wind. On the main jetty, Captain Adrien Montreuil watches his crew unloading barrels of rum and bales of indigo – the fruits of their latest modest haul. Thirty-four years old, Montreuil is a tall French buccaneer sporting a thick, damp mane of brown hair and a frayed tricorne. His sun-tanned face bears the marks of many crossings and as many battles. A crooked smile lights his features when he jokes with two of his men, but his clear eyes, narrowed with mistrust, constantly scan the surroundings.

Montreuil is admired by his men for his charisma and eloquence. He is also said to be superstitious, which he does not deny: a medal of Saint Barbara, the patron saint of gunners, hangs around his neck as a talisman. Under his soaked linen shirt he also hides a small cloth pouch containing gris-gris – a few chicken bones and dried herbs – given to him by a houngan from Saint-Domingue. The captain believes in it strongly: he swears these amulets have protected him more than once from enemy shot. When one of his men sneezes to port, Adrien makes a discreet hand gesture to ward off bad luck, quickly tracing a cross in the air. No one dares to mock these habits, for Montreuil has proven his bravery and skill in navigation and in combat many times over. Under his orders, the brig-schooner *La Fortune* has relentlessly scoured the Caribbean, winning its share of booty and carving a solid reputation for its captain.

This evening, Montreuil waits beneath the crooked sign of a tavern called the Whistling Pig. The dive is famous on the island for its tafia (a harsh brown rum) and its frequent fights. As the rain intensifies, the captain allows himself a moment of contemplation. From the top of the cliff overlooking the bay one can make out the massive silhouette of Fort de Rocher built by Le Vasseur years earlier: the cannons of the fortress point out to sea, immovable sentinels of stone and iron keeping watch for hypothetical Spanish sails. Around the fort stand the few wooden buildings of the little pirate town: warehouses, taverns, brothels and fences' stalls where doubloons, spices and other stolen goods are traded. Light filters through ill-fitting shutters and bursts of voices pierce the night, evidence of the frenetic life led by this motley brotherhood of rogues, the Brethren of the Coast who have come from all over Europe and beyond. French, English, Dutch, former maroon slaves and Creole boucaniers rub shoulders here, united by the lure of gain.

Montreuil draws in a lungful of air saturated with spray and braise smoke. Behind him, Henri Duval, his quartermaster and long-time friend, finishes giving instructions to the topmen who are busy furling *La Fortune's* sails in preparation for the night. Henri soon joins the captain under the tavern's awning. Five years older, Duval is a stocky Breton with a salt-and-pepper beard, a large knife tucked into his belt. His lively, laughing glance contrasts with his role as quartermaster, traditionally responsible for enforcing discipline. Montreuil knows, however, that Henri is his most loyal ally: the two men have sailed together for almost ten years, facing sea and fire side by side.

'Another squall coming down on us, Captain,' grumbles Henri, shaking his dripping tricorne.

'We've known worse downpours, my friend. This water blesses our return; rather think of the half-full chests,' replies Montreuil, raising his voice to drown a distant thunderclap.

Henri chuckles softly: 'Chests half full or half empty? Our lads were hoping for more than those barrels of tafia and a few bales of indigo...'

Montreuil shrugs. He knows that after weeks at sea for a modest prize, his buccaneers feel short of funds. 'Don't be mistaken, this tafia will do the trick. The tavern keepers of Port-de-Paix will pay a good price for this alcohol. Then we can consider a richer target. Trust me, Henri, the next one will be the right one.' He punctuates his sentence by squeezing his friend's shoulder

with a confident grip.

Inside the Whistling Pig, warm, smoky heat greets the two sailors. Flickering candles dimly light the room cluttered with sticky tables and rickety benches. A smell of sweat, spiced rum and tobacco floats in the air. At the back, a serving girl with her skirts hitched up barely escapes the clumsy embrace of a dead-drunk English privateer, provoking the belly laughs of the crowd. In a corner, a viola da gamba player plucks a plaintive air that is sometimes drowned out by the shouts of dice players. Montreuil and Duval make their way to the counter. Isabelle, the imposing mixed-race landlady, greets them with a wink before serving them two tankards brimming with amber liquid. The captain toasts carefully, avoiding clinking his glass against Henri's – he respects the superstition that the sound of glass attracts bad luck at sea.

'To our return, and to the next fortune!' cries Montreuil. The tafia – a homemade brown rum – flows down his throat with a familiar harshness. He savours for a moment the reassuring hubbub of the tavern. Here, no vice is forbidden except cowardice. The law that reigns is that of the chasse-partie, the pirate code, and everyone knows it must be respected under penalty of severe punishment. Montreuil casts a circular glance at the customers around the tables: he recognises a few villainous faces of rivals and potential allies. Miguel Mendoza, a renegade former Spanish privateer, is playing cards and obviously cheating. Not far away, Edward Murray, a flamboyant Scottish buccaneer, noisily shows off the gold earring he tore from a merchant captain's ear. This dangerous microcosm is his home.

It is then that a familiar silhouette approaches Montreuil, limping slightly: Jean Desmarais, the surgeon of La Fortune, a lanky Norman decked in a hat misshapen by the rain. 'Captain,' he whispers in a halting voice, 'I have news that might interest you. Word at the port is that a heavily laden Spanish ship will soon be setting sail from Maracaibo to Havana... and that it will sail alone.' Desmarais always has his ear where it needs to be, a precious quality. Montreuil raises an interested eyebrow, while Henri Duval leans in as well, his gaze suddenly alight with hope and greed. A lone prize from the Spanish colonies could mean money they'd hardly know what to do with: chests of piastres, bars of Potosí silver or sacks of cocoa, whatever – anything that shines or sells tempts them.

'Where did you get that?' asks Montreuil, cautious despite the excitement that already knots his insides.

'From a Dutch pilot who has just docked with his sloop. He says he barely escaped a Spanish galleon under repair in Cartagena. According to him, this galleon – El Santo Niño – is to carry the royal tribute of New Granada. But damage has delayed her; she will not be able to catch up with the main Tierra Firme fleet that left earlier. She will be a straggler, alone on the waves, an ideal prey,' Desmarais whispers with a knowing wink. The surgeon, though no fierce fighter, loves adventure and especially the promise of hefty shares of booty.

Montreuil exchanges a look with his quartermaster. Both understand what it means: an isolated Spanish galleon carrying the treasure of the mainland is an opportunity that rarely comes. 'By the Blessed Virgin, if that's true...', murmurs Henri, made suddenly more pious than usual by drink and excitement. The captain rubs his beard thoughtfully. His mind is already calculating: they will need to set sail quickly, surprise the ship before she rejoins some convoy or finds refuge under the escort of a Spanish ship of the line.

A lightning bolt streaks the night sky outside and, almost immediately, a rumble of thunder makes the thick air vibrate. Montreuil takes this as a sign of fate: the gods of the sea have just approved our plan, he says to himself. He drains his tankard of tafia in one gulp, then noisily slams the vessel on the counter to draw the attention of his men scattered around the room. 'My wolves!' he booms in his baritone voice; conversations fall silent here and there. 'Enjoy yourselves tonight, because tomorrow at dawn La Fortune sets sail again! A rich Spanish galleon awaits us somewhere on the waves. Those whose hearts are brave and souls hungry for glory and gold, prepare yourselves to write the finest page of our history!' A cheer rings through the tavern. Montreuil's men – and even other pirates lured by the announcement – raise their cups shouting 'To the Spaniard! Death to the hidalgos!' In the shadows, however,

some eyes grow more calculating. For while the prospect of treasure excites all buccaneers, it also arouses personal greed. In the crowd, the seeds of future intrigues are already sprouting, invisible to the captain. For now, Montreuil revels in the general enthusiasm. He swears inwardly to follow the will of heaven and not to tempt fate too much: at daybreak he will sacrifice a rooster to win providence's favour, as he does before every great battle. His medal of Saint Barbara seems to glow faintly in the candlelight – a silent promise of protection for the adventure ahead.

Chapter 2 : The Buccaneers' Code

At the pale dawn of the next day the sky has cleared as if by magic. Not a cloud troubles the horizon, and a steady east wind makes the rigging of La Fortune rattle. Montreuil's trim, agile brig-schooner rocks gently at anchor near the jetty. It is a medium-sized vessel, painted black with a thin white line along its sleek hull. On its quarterdeck proudly floats the blood-red flag of the French buccaneers – the red standard meaning that no quarter will be given to an enemy taken with arms in hand. Montreuil has preferred this flag to the sinister black pennant adorned with a skull which some of his comrades fly: for him, the red is as much a challenge as a talisman. He often repeats to himself that the red of the flag wards off ill luck.

Before weighing anchor Captain Montreuil gathers his entire crew on deck. Forty-two men crowd around him in the golden morning light. Among them, standing in the front row, are Henri Duval the quartermaster; Jean Desmarais the surgeon; Geoffroy the muscular boatswain with knotted arms; Miguel the one-eyed gunner who once served on the Dunkirkers; and Yann, a very young Breton topman who still looks innocent. Some have their faces crumpled by last night's hangover, but all display a gleam of greed in their eyes.

Montreuil paces, his polished boots striking the oak deck. In a loud voice he announces: 'My brothers, we are setting out to hunt a Spanish galleon full of gold and silver. Before we begin, everyone here must know the rules of our enterprise. Let none forget that we are bound by the *chasse-partie*, our code of honour and division!' He brandishes a parchment nailed to a board, on which the clauses of their agreement are scribbled in French. He reads them out to refresh their memories:

- 'First: Every man on board is entitled to an equal share of the booty; the captain and the quartermaster will each receive two shares for their office. Let that be enough to recognise the risks and responsibilities they bear.'
- 'Second: Whoever steals or hides anything from the common booty to the detriment of the company will be severely punished – by twenty lashes from the cat-o'-nine-tails or abandonment on a desert island depending on the gravity of the offence.' At these words, Montreuil lets his gaze rest deliberately on a few cutthroats with dubious reputations to ensure they take the warning to heart.
- 'Third: No one shall draw his sword or pistol against a comrade on board. In the case of an irreconcilable quarrel it will be settled ashore, in a duel under the quartermaster's arbitration.'
- 'Fourth: Any man wounded in battle will receive compensation from the booty in addition to his share: 200 piastres for a lost eye, 500 for a hand or a leg, 1,500 if he loses both legs. This guarantee is our pride; it distinguishes the Brethren of the Coast from the wretches who serve in the royal navies without reward.'
- 'Fifth: It is understood that during the attack the captain has absolute command. But outside combat, important decisions will be put to a vote of the crew where each will have an equal voice.'
- 'Sixth: No women on board nor young boys disguised as women – on pain of death.' A few lewd laughs erupt in the assembly, some pretending to look under their neighbours' rags. The rule is well known: superstition holds that a woman on a ship brings bad luck and sows discord.
- 'Seventh: No gambling with dice or cards for money aboard, nor candles lit after eight in the evening. Thus we preserve caution.'

– ‘Finally: No one will speak of abandoning the life of a pirate until each has gathered at least 1,000 livres of loot for himself. We are together in good fortune and ill.’

The silence is now total, only disturbed by the lapping of the waves against the hull. Montreuil plants his gaze into that of his men and concludes solemnly: ‘Do you swear to respect these articles as we did when we set out last time?’ In unison, the pirates raise their right hands or brandish their cutlasses and roar: ‘We swear it!’ The captain cannot help but smile. It is a fine pack of sea wolves he commands there, bound together by this pact. Despite their personal greed, the code obliges them to unity – at least as long as discipline holds. He knows, however, that the promise of immense treasure will put their brotherhood to a severe test when the gold flows on deck. Gold is a treacherous serpent, thinks Montreuil. It can strangle the firmest loyalty. Chasing this dark thought away, he decides he will deal with problems as they arise.

For now, he must take advantage of the effect of this collective oath to galvanise the crew. ‘To your posts!’ he orders, going to take his place near the helm. ‘We weigh anchor at once. May God and the Devil favour us, and woe betide the Spaniards on our path!’

The men scatter, each to his task, driven by the boatswain’s barks. They slowly heave up the anchor with the capstan – a dozen sturdy fellows marching in time around the wooden axis and chanting a deep refrain. On the forecastle the topmen hoist the mainsail and the foresail, taking advantage of the favourable wind. La Fortune comes alive: the ship shivers, the canvas snaps and then billows proudly. With a turn of the helm, Montreuil aims the bow toward the entrance of Turtle lagoon, between the reefs. Standing behind the great oak wheel, he feels a fierce exultation rising in him. This moment when the ship responds to his hand and adventure opens before the bow like a promise is what he loves above all.

Henri Duval climbs onto the aftercastle and, spyglass in hand, scans the narrow coral-lined channel. The rising sun illuminates the turquoise waters. ‘Nothing to report, Captain. No rocks in sight; the exit is clear,’ he reports. Montreuil nods. Behind them, Tortuga gradually recedes: one can still make out the silhouette of the fort and the masts of ships at anchor in the bay; then the island’s luxuriant vegetation hides them from view.

As they head south-east toward Hispaniola, Montreuil briefly entrusts the helm to a helmsman and goes down to his cabin. On his navigation table he finds a cage where a young black rooster is nervously clucking. Following his superstitious ritual before every great departure, the captain takes the frightened animal from its cage. In a corner of the cabin a makeshift altar has been set up: a candle, a small bowl and a crude symbol of Yemaya, the sea goddess in Afro-Caribbean cults whom Montreuil respects as much as the Christian saints – prudence requires, one never knows which deity is listening. Montreuil murmurs an indistinct prayer in French mixed with Spanish and Creole, then slits the rooster’s throat with a swift gesture over the bowl. The warm blood spreads and a few drops splatter the altar. ‘Mama Yemaya, protect us from storms and sea monsters; Saint Barbara, turn aside from us the cannonballs and grapeshot,’ he whispers fervently, his brow humbly lowered. Once the sacrifice is completed he wraps the bloodless rooster in a cloth: he will have it thrown overboard as an offering to the waves a little later.

Back on deck, Montreuil meets the intrigued looks of some crew members. They are used to his strange practices, and many of them see no objection as long as he leads them to success. Besides, many share other superstitions: thus Miguel the gunner always carries a dried clover, and Yann, the young topman, never parts with a piece of wood from the chapel of a shipwrecked vessel, supposed to prevent him from drowning. Among these rough men, the line between religion and superstition is blurred; all implore luck in their own way.

The day advances, paced by the manoeuvres. La Fortune hugs the north coast of Hispaniola, avoiding shoals. Offshore, schools of flying fish streak the azure surface, and at times one sees the misty spout of a whale in the distance. The officers take turns at the helm and check the course. In the afternoon the ship enters the Windward Passage, a breezy strait between Cuba and Haiti conducive to fast currents. Montreuil, holding a compass, checks their position on his salt-stained chart. According to his calculations they should soon veer due west toward the Gulf

of Honduras, for that is where the delayed galleon from Maracaibo will likely cross.

On deck, the atmosphere oscillates between excitement and contained tension. Everyone prepares weapons and equipment for the confrontation they hope is near. Under a blazing sun, cutlasses are sharpened and muskets oiled to prevent them from misfiring at the crucial moment. Master gunner Miguel inspects the six chase cannons on port and starboard, checking the fuses and the powder in the cartridges. He has crates of chain-shot brought within reach – two balls linked by a chain, terrible for tearing enemy sails.

Henri Duval busies himself dividing the crew into two parties for the boarding: he appoints section leaders and ensures each man has a precise assignment once aboard the enemy. ‘You, Achille, you will lead the grenadiers on the Spanish forecastle; you, Laurent, you will look after the powder and the hold,’ he orders, referring to those who will throw homemade hand grenades onto the enemy deck, as their plan stipulates. Montreuil has indeed promised a special reward to the first man who plants the French flag on the galleon’s quarterdeck and to the one who captures a Spanish officer to ransom. These bonuses stoke everyone’s fighting ardour.

Toward the evening of the second day at sea an event interrupts the routine: the wind suddenly dies and La Fortune finds herself becalmed on a mirror-like sea. The ship barely moves, the sails hang listlessly along the masts. A clammy, silent heat settles. Montreuil feels uneasiness invade him: the calm is, for him, an ominous sign. He already hears some sailors muttering that bad luck is lurking. ‘Not a breath of air... it’s rotten luck,’ grumbles an old helmsman, mechanically turning a copper charm in his hand. Another whistles to call the wind: ‘Fouuu, fouuu...’ Montreuil whirls around, furious: ‘Do not whistle on board! Do you want to call the storm?’ he thunders, more worried than truly angry.

Immediately, the guilty topman crosses himself and swallows his whistle, aware he has committed a superstitious faux pas. The heavy wait drags on into the night. The pirates, usually so combative, speak in low voices. Some already blame fate: ‘We left on a Friday morning; I knew it wasn’t good...’ mutters one. Another taps wood to ward off bad luck. Montreuil, taciturn, obstinately scans the starry horizon. Yemaya is testing me, he thinks. Perhaps he has not poured enough rum on the sea in addition to the sacrificed rooster? He thinks for a moment of ordering a second sacrifice, but he has no more rooster at hand.

He decides to pull himself together and to appear reassuring. ‘It’s only a passing calm, friends. The moon smiles on us tonight: look how full and high it is,’ he says, pointing to the large whitish disc. ‘Tomorrow at dawn a good wind will rise. Until then, rest. We shall soon need all our strength.’ His words are meant to be confident, and Henri Duval approves loudly to lend weight to the captain’s optimism. A few men nod and return to their hammocks or their watch, heartened.

Yet Montreuil himself sleeps poorly that night. He stays a good part of the dark hours on the aftercastle, observing the vault of heaven. He looks for a sign in the stars – Orion, the eternal hunter, shines bright, and the Pole Star is clear. Nothing sinister, he reassures himself. At dawn, as if by miracle, a light breeze rises, swelling the sails once more. A collective sigh of relief runs across the deck when La Fortune picks up speed again. Montreuil secretly thanks providence. Perhaps the sea simply wished to test their determination.

Chapter 3 : The Appearance of the Target

On the third day of sailing, around midday, the blazing sun makes the horizon shimmer. From high in the mast, the young topman Yann, keeping watch on the crosstrees, scans without respite the hazy line between sky and water. The crew is on alert: according to Montreuil’s estimates, they should cross the supposed route of the Spanish galleon at any moment if it left Maracaibo as expected. On deck there are no more songs or coarse laughter: each man watches, musket or pike at hand, heart pounding with impatience.

Suddenly a shrill cry comes from above: ‘Sail to starboard ahead!’ It is Yann, perched on the yard, frantically waving his arm toward the north-west. Montreuil leaps, the spyglass already

drawn and pointed in the indicated direction. His heart skips a beat when he sees it: about three nautical miles away, one can make out the imposing silhouette of a large sailing ship progressing slowly, almost against the wind. To the naked eye it is only a cream-coloured triangle on the azure, but through his telescope Montreuil clearly distinguishes the bulky, heavy profile of a galleon: high aftercastle, square sails billowing on three masts, high hull. He even spots the gleam of a flag in the rigging – yellow and red no doubt: the Spanish flag.

‘That’s her,’ breathes the captain, his throat a little dry. ‘El Santo Niño, right in our nets. My brothers, the hunt begins.’ A feverish murmur of excitement runs through the crew. All eyes turn toward the distant speck. Montreuil, lucid, knows they hold a unique chance. The galleon sails slower than they do; she seems isolated. They still have to approach discreetly and board before she identifies them as pirates and tries to flee or fight.

Immediately Montreuil gives his orders: ‘Port tack, all! We’ll place ourselves in her wake. Down with the red colours, hoist the Spanish flag!’ In the blink of an eye the men obey. The helmsman turns the wheel to line La Fortune behind the galleon’s path, while a topman lowers the red flag and in its place hoists a Spanish standard kept precisely for this sort of ruse. It is common for buccaneers to sail under false flags to approach their prey without arousing suspicion. Montreuil counts on the decreasing distance to maintain the illusion. Seen from afar, La Fortune, a smaller vessel, might pass for an allied escort.

‘Show less sail so we look sluggish!’ he adds. The mainsail is slightly brailled in order not to close too quickly on the target. The manoeuvre must appear natural: a Spanish ship (theirs, in this case) simply catching up to a straggling companion. Montreuil knows that the Spaniards, outside their organised fleets, fear unknown encounters. He prays that the opposing captain’s suspicion is not too strong.

The two ships draw closer progressively over the course of an hour. Through the telescope Montreuil studies the galleon: he judges it to be about 300 tons, a fine large merchantman armed perhaps with twenty guns. La Fortune, lighter, only carries fourteen, but her advantage is surprise and agility. He notes an encouraging detail: the galleon shows signs of recent repair, a poorly trimmed mizzen and a heavy pitch. They are likely just out of the yard, which corroborates the Dutch pilot’s story. The aftercastle bears a name painted in gold – Montreuil makes out El Santo Niño. No doubt about it, this is the target.

On the deck of La Fortune the pirates silently prepare for action. Henri Duval passes among them for a last reminder: muskets primed but kept out of sight behind the bulwarks, grappling hooks ready to be thrown, sabres drawn but concealed. The cannons are loaded with grapeshot and aimed low, but Montreuil has ordered them to fire only if absolutely necessary. If they could board without a shot, that would be ideal. This level of restraint is hard for the men, whose excitement tenses every muscle, but they obey their captain’s instruction, aware that the ruse will offer them a cleaner success.

Soon they are no more than three cables’ lengths from El Santo Niño. Montreuil has a signal flag hoisted to request to speak – a common formality between supposedly allied ships meeting on the ocean. From the galleon’s aftercastle they answer by sending up interrogation flags. Montreuil smiles: the prey does not visibly take flight, perhaps reassured by the Spanish flag that La Fortune displays. Nevertheless, he remains cautious: he knows that the galleon certainly has more men than they do, soldiers, and that a single well-placed shot could destroy their small ship.

He turns toward his crew: ‘At the first whistle, fire at will at their sails and tops, then immediate boarding on starboard. May God keep you, my brothers.’ All acquiesce with a nod or a concentrated grunt. A few quickly kiss a pendant or touch a lucky tattoo. Henri Duval discreetly raises his sabre in salute, and Montreuil knows he can count on him to lead the boarding by his side.

The vessels are now only three cables apart. Montreuil sees distinctly silhouettes busy on the enemy deck. A Spanish officer wearing a broad black hat brandishes a speaking-trumpet and calls in Spanish: « Qué navío es ? ». Montreuil, who speaks Spanish fluently, plants his feet on

his quarterdeck and replies, shouting: « ¡El Toro de Sevilla, navío de escolta, ¿cuál es el vuestro? ». He has invented this name and pretends to be an escort of the fleet. A tense silence follows. Montreuil fears for a moment that the Spaniards will see through the ploy. His heart beats so hard that he seems to hear it in his temples. Then a voice answers: « Somos El Santo Niño, de Maracaibo. » They have taken the bait. Better still, they show no immediate alarm.

Taking advantage of this relative trust, La Fortune reduces the distance still further. Only a cable now. The bearded, villainous faces of the buccaneers are now visible from the galleon's deck, and a few Spaniards begin to find the heterogeneous attire of these supposed royal sailors odd: many open shirts and bandanas, few uniforms. Montreuil knows the critical moment has come: the ruse will be exposed any second.

Then, with a swift gesture, he raises to his lips a silver whistle hanging from his neck and emits a piercing sound. It is the signal. At once La Fortune brutally hoists the red flag to the top of the mast and opens her gunports. A thunderclap ensues: all the starboard cannons fire together in a deafening crash. The volley of grapeshot and scrap sweeps the flank of the galleon in a cloud of powder. Wood is heard cracking; yards split. The enemy sails are lacerated; the main topsail is partly torn by the impact of the chain-shot specially intended for that. On the galleon's forecastle cries of surprise and pain ring out: the murderous discharge has felled several Spanish sailors who collapse, cut down by shards of metal.

'To boarding!' roars Montreuil in a fierce voice, raising his gleaming sabre. La Fortune has just rammed her hull against that of the galleon on the starboard side. Grappling hooks fly through the air; thrown by trained arms they catch on the enemy rail and the ropes tauten. The two ships lock together in a deadly embrace.

Without hesitation, Montreuil is among the first to leap. In a bound he crosses the rail and lands on the deck of El Santo Niño. After him a score of screaming freebooters surge, pistol in hand and cutlass between their teeth. The din is indescribable: shots crack in all directions; the surprised Spaniards try to organise themselves. An enemy officer brandishes his sword and rushes toward Montreuil, shouting: « ¡Piratas! » The captain parries the blow just in time, blade against blade, while Henri Duval appears and brings the butt of a pistol down on the officer's temple, who collapses, stunned.

The fight spreads across the whole deck. The pirates, more agile, make the most of the surprise. Miguel the gunner, too impatient to reload his blunderbuss, uses his mace to knock out a Spanish artilleryman. Young Yann, despite the fear twisting his gut, doggedly stabs at an opponent twice his size. Jean Desmarais, our surgeon, a strange figure in the thick of battle, is already busy bandaging a pirate's arm wounded by a pike while holding a pistol in his other hand to keep anyone who comes too close at bay. Montreuil, duelling with an enemy sergeant, feints skilfully and drives his blade into the man's flank. May God forgive his soul, he thinks fleetingly as he pulls the blood-stained steel free. Around him his men gain ground. But the Spaniards are numerous – at least fifty, sailors and soldiers combined – and they begin to put up fierce resistance now that they are cornered. On the staircase leading to the aftercastle a group of Spanish arquebusiers has entrenched itself and fires at point-blank range. A ball whistles past Montreuil's ear and goes on to smash the head of a pirate behind him, who drops dead. The captain suppresses a retch on recognising the fixed face of Guillaume, a jovial Gascon who had sung the whole voyage. There's no time for emotion: Montreuil snatches a pistol from his belt and coldly aims at the Spanish musketeer responsible: bang! The man collapses, tumbling down the stairs.

Meanwhile Henri Duval leads an assault toward the stern. Followed by five strong men, he smashes in the door of the pantry where several Spaniards retreat. A few shots ring out inside, then silence – a sign that the pocket of resistance has been neutralised.

A victorious cry rings out from the foredeck: 'Flag hoisted!' It is Achille, the leader of the pirate grenadiers, who triumphantly brandishes at the top of the foremast a makeshift French flag. The Spanish defenders lose heart on seeing their flag lowered and the enemy seize their positions. Many throw down their weapons crying for mercy. Others continue to fight

desperately, but confusion and panic grip them. Soon the last resisters are cornered near the helm.

‘Surrender!’ yells Montreuil in Spanish, lifting his blood-stained sabre above his head.

‘Ríndanse o mueren!’ Surrender or die. The Spanish captain, wounded in the arm, is supported by two of his men. The galleon’s deck is no more than a field of debris and bodies, slippery with blood and seawater. The officer understands all is lost. He lets his sword fall with a weary gesture and inclines his head in sign of capitulation. At once the pirates disarm them and gather them kneeling in the centre of the deck.

A tremendous clamour rises from the attackers’ side: they have succeeded. A scent of powder still hangs in the air, mingled with the more acrid smell of blood. Columns of smoke escape from two fires quickly mastered. Montreuil, panting and his arm aching from a superficial graze, casts a circular glance to assess the situation. They mourn the loss of a few of their own – at least five pirates lie dead, including poor Guillaume – but the victory is indisputable. Opposite, more than a dozen Spaniards have been killed and the others – about thirty – surrender.

Chapter 4 : The Spaniards’ Gold

Henri Duval approaches Montreuil, a bandana covering a cut on his forehead. His eyes shine with euphoria. ‘Captain, the ship is ours!’ he whispers, squeezing his friend’s arm. Montreuil nods in silence then, stepping to the middle of the conquered deck, he raises his voice so all can hear: ‘Victory, my brothers! This treasure is ours by the grace of heaven and our courage.’ A thunder of applause, shouts and laughter answers him. Some pirates embrace their neighbour; others fire pistols in the air in exuberance.

Montreuil calls out to Desmarais: ‘Surgeon, tend to the wounded, ours first and then theirs. Let no one say we let a prisoner die for lack of care.’ That was a tacit clause of their code of honour: gratuitous cruelty was not prized except against implacable foes. These Spaniards have surrendered; they should be treated properly at least until they can be put ashore somewhere as sailors without a ship.

Desmarais nods and organises a team to bandage wounds, tying tourniquets here, sewing up a gash there. Montreuil himself feels his shoulder bruised from a blow during the battle, but it is superficial. He looks around for Yann: the young topman is sitting against the mast, dazed, blood on his jerkin. Montreuil hurries over, fearing he is seriously hurt: ‘Are you all right, lad?’ Yann raises eyes wide with emotion toward him: ‘Yes... it isn’t my blood... I... I killed a man, Captain.’ Montreuil places a compassionate hand on the trembling boy’s neck. ‘You did what you had to do to survive. Pull yourself together. You fought bravely.’ He gives him a canteen of water to drink, then entrusts the still-shaken young pirate to an older comrade for comfort. Montreuil knows this first life taken will probably haunt Yann – all pirates carry certain ghosts. I have a whole crew around me, he thinks fleetingly, and I have learned to toast with them rather than fear them.

Regaining his composure, the captain turns to the captured Spanish officers. The opposing captain lies propped against the rail, pale but conscious, his arm bleeding abundantly under the makeshift bandage Desmarais has applied. Montreuil crouches to his level and says politely in Spanish: « Capitán, hemos tomado su barco. Díganos dónde guardan el tesoro y nadie más morirá. » (Captain, we have taken your ship. Tell us where the treasure is kept and no one else will die.) The Spanish officer, a moustached man in his forties, stares back at him with a mix of dignity and impotent rage. At last he spits bitterly: « En la santabárbara no hay más que pólvora. El oro... está abajo, en la bodega, bajo guardia. » Montreuil signals to two of his men to go down to the hold. They return a few minutes later, eyes wide with joy: ‘Captain, it’s prodigious... you should come see this!’

In the heart of El Santo Niño’s hold the air is heavy with scents of spices and rum. A relative darkness reigns, pierced only by the wavering glow of torches held by two pirates who descended ahead. Montreuil, followed by Henri Duval and a few others, jumps down through

the hatch into the ship's belly. His boots hit a firm floor and a frisson of anticipation runs down his spine. He finds himself in the main tween-decks where the cargo is stored.

What Montreuil discovers in the torchlight exceeds his wildest hopes. Lined up along the ribs of the hull are several dozen wooden chests bound with iron, all stamped with the royal seal of Spain. Some are ajar, revealing piles of gleaming silver pieces – doubtless pieces of eight, those Spanish dollars that serve as a universal currency in the Americas. Nearby Montreuil sees burst leather sacks spilling streams of gold dust or cocoa, rough ingots marked with the Potosí stamp, and even some crates filled with uncut precious stones – emeralds, ambers, pearls. A small upturned casket has let a clutch of gold doubloons roll across the floor, which one pirate picks up laughing in disbelief.

Henri Duval lets out an admiring whistle as he theatrically crosses himself, torn between joy and the superstitious fear of so much accumulated wealth. 'Name of a dog, it's the ransom of a king...' he murmurs. Montreuil kneels in front of a gaping chest and plunges his hands in by the handful. The silver coins trickle through his fingers with an intoxicating clink. He raises a handful of piastres to his face: on each coin gleams the cross and the Spanish coat of arms. Tears almost come to his eyes so great is his emotion; he bursts into a clear, triumphant laugh that echoes off the frames of the hold. 'My brothers, by Saint Barbara, we have taken the gold of Spain!' His voice ricochets in echo. A deafening hurrah shakes the hold as the pirates present acclaim their captain and congratulate each other. Some start to dance an improvised jig around the chests; others begin a solemn verse of *La Belle Épine*, a well-known buccaneer song, adapting the words to celebrate the fall of a Spanish galleon.

Montreuil allows his men to savour this moment, but not for too long. Soon he takes things in hand: 'Come on, calm down; we'll have time to celebrate ashore. Now we must inventory and transfer part of this treasure onto *La Fortune*.' Indeed it is out of the question to overload their own schooner to the point of slowing her. Montreuil decides they will divide the loot: half on *La Fortune*, the other will remain in the galleon which they will sail as a prize. It is the custom among buccaneers to bring captured ships into port to sell them or incorporate them into their fleet. Here *El Santo Niño* itself is worth a fortune, not counting its cargo, provided they can sail it to Tortuga without incident.

Henri organises a human chain to hoist the chests onto the deck. The pirates spare no effort – carrying gold is not a chore that is hard to motivate. Even the lightly wounded insist on taking part, euphoric. Under the biting sun of the afternoon one soon sees a dozen gleaming chests lined up on the galleon's deck. Montreuil has them opened one by one to estimate the booty's value in everyone's eyes, transparency being obligatory according to the code.

The contents are almost unreal: the first chest contains 4,000 pieces of eight in silver, as much as a simple pirate could earn in several years of modest raiding. A murmur of astonishment runs through the crew when Montreuil announces it. The second contains massive silver ingots – probably from the Zacatecas or Peruvian mines – so heavy that it takes two men to lift one. In another, there is a pyramid of gold doubloons gleaming, stamped with the seal of Nueva Granada, probably the year's taxes for the Crown. Other chests hold more unexpected but just as precious things: bags of cochineal (the carmine red dye much prized), bales of blond tobacco from Cuba, nuggets of panned gold, and even liturgical objects in solid gold (a finely chiselled chalice inlaid with rubies, an altar cross) clearly taken from some colonial church. There is also, precious beyond immediate monetary value, a bundle of bills of exchange and credits on Spanish trading houses – Montreuil knows that in Tortuga traffickers will be glad to buy them cheaply to cash them in Seville or Cadiz.

Seeing this heap of riches several pirates must suppress instinctive gestures of greed. Montreuil notices it: thus he catches Miguel the gunner slipping a handful of pearls into his pocket. The captain approaches calmly and whispers: 'Miguel, none of that among us: put those pearls back. You will have your share, my friend, as agreed.' The one-eyed man grumbles and for a moment Montreuil fears an outburst of defiance, but finally Miguel opens his large calloused hand and lets the pearls fall back into the chest. 'That's good,' concludes Montreuil,

placing a firm hand on his shoulder to seal the matter. He has just avoided the first breach of the code: internal theft. Nothing sows discord like tolerating that sort of lapse.

After nearly two hours of labour the division is complete. Montreuil has assigned sixteen men, under the command of Geoffroy the boatswain, to sail the galleon to Tortuga, while the rest will return to La Fortune. They will sail in consort. He has made this decision strategically: thus, if danger should arise (a meeting with a Spanish frigate, a storm...), the two ships could support each other or separate as needed. They therefore transfer part of the treasure onto La Fortune, notably the gold and the easiest gems to carry, while the heavier silver remains mainly in El Santo Niño.

The pirates still cannot believe their sudden fortune. On La Fortune, where Montreuil has returned, the atmosphere is euphoric. On the deck cluttered with chests some belt out La Caroline, a buccaneer song celebrating a rich haul, others shake their comrades' hands laughing foolishly, as if to make sure they aren't dreaming. Henri Duval, however, remains calm and methodical, already busy writing down on an improvised register the inventory of the loot: he takes his role as quartermaster seriously, for it will fall to him to distribute fairly the shares to each man once back in port.

Montreuil at last allows himself a moment of respite. He leans on La Fortune's rail and watches El Santo Niño sailing now beside her under reduced sail. The galleon has suffered a few minor damages, but she holds the sea. The captain breathes in the marine air deeply, as if already smelling the scent of wealth. He lets his mind wander for a moment: what will he do with his colossal share? Perhaps he will buy himself a fine house in Port-de-Paix or Cap-Français, with a veranda overlooking the sea. He imagines the gentle warmth of a home without danger, far from sabres and gunports. Part of him even thinks that he could end his buccaneer career on a high note, now that fortune has smiled on him to this extent. All the more so because superstition in his soul whispers that fate is never so generous without asking for something in return. This dazzling success might well stoke envy in men or gods...

Chasing these thoughts, Montreuil feels in his pocket for his Saint Barbara medal and kisses it discreetly. Then he slips his hand inside his doublet and touches his gris-gris pouch: strangely, he finds it is no longer there. His voodoo amulet, which he had had for three years, has vanished! He frantically searches his belongings, fingers the folds of his belt – nothing. He recalls the battle, wondering whether the pouch might have come loose during a brawl. This loss worries him far more than anything that has happened. To him it is a very bad sign. Losing his gris-gris in the midst of victory could herald a sudden reversal of fortune. Montreuil instinctively raises his eyes to the sky, as if looking there for a warning. But the radiant sun and calm sea betray nothing sinister.

He decides not to speak of it and to remain vigilant. Perhaps one of his men will pick up the pouch later while cleaning the galleon's deck. In the meantime he does not want to tarnish the prevailing joy with his fears. He puts his tricorne back on, firms his expression and goes to assist Henri in safely guarding the Spanish prisoners. These, once the wounded have been roughly tended, have been separated: some locked up in the galleon's hold, others tied up in that of La Fortune. Montreuil has promised the officer they will be freed on the first neutral or friendly coast they meet – without weapons or food, which amounts to marooning them as pirate custom dictates, but leaving them their lives. Truth be told, Montreuil intends to land them on an isolated Cuban shore, not far from a plantation, so that they have a chance of salvation. It is more clemency than many of his peers would show, but Montreuil is not known for cruelty. He prefers to avoid weighing down his conscience too much, aware that he already has plenty of blood on his hands.

By late afternoon everything is in order. The two ships now beat due north-east, heading for Tortuga with their treasure. The wind is fair; everything seems perfect. Montreuil dines on a ship's biscuit softened in tafia; he even shares a double ration of this rum with everyone as a celebration. On the quarterdeck a few pirates improvise a tune on violin and flute, now that the alarm of battle is behind them. A feeling of collective triumph reigns, and Montreuil is surprised

to burst into laughter at the somewhat crude jokes of Desmarais and Duval about what they will do with their gold.

The sun sets in purple glory, and Montreuil, leaning on the rail, watches the myriad colours in the sky. If all goes well they should be in sight of Turtle Island before noon tomorrow, according to his navigation. At this thought he feels a mixture of impatience – to announce the news, to parade in port as rich heroes – and a strange apprehension. It is a little too good. Come on, stop, old wolf, he scolds himself. You have led your people to victory; savour it instead.

To calm his doubts, he decides to entrust the watch to Henri Duval for the night. 'Henri, my friend, I leave the watch to you. I'm going to sleep a bit. Wake me at the slightest suspicious sign.' Henri nods with a smile: 'Go rest, captain. You've earned it. I will watch over your gold like over my own mother.' Montreuil briefly grips his friend's forearm as thanks, then goes down to his cabin. Exhausted by the effort and emotions, he collapses on his bunk without even taking off his boots, the reassuring lapping of the sea against the hull as a lullaby.

If he had known what was afoot, Montreuil would certainly not have closed his eyes so easily.

End of the first part.